

REUTERS/JAYANTA SHAW



**MAOIST LEADER
KISHENJI
(CENTRE,
WITH BACK
TO CAMERA)
ADDRESSES
THE MEDIA**

trained and well-equipped police forces. "Also, the intellectual and material support extended by unsuspecting NGOs and civil society adds to the problem," he said.

Chidambaram took pains to explain how large tracts of land first had to be cleared of Maoists before the state administration could step in with development. The first thing was to regain control of the areas dominated by the rebels. "The security forces first have to dominate the area, establish civil administration and then the state governments have to rush in resources and take over the development. There can be no halfway houses. It can be either civil administration or what the Naxals call a liberated zone," he said. Sources said that the Maoists did not like the fact that security forces continued to squat in the area they

had reclaimed. Earlier, they used to clear the area and move out and the rebels would soon return. Now, the security forces are following the army's grid square pattern—dividing the area into grids and ensuring coverage of each square kilometre.

Though festering for the past 20 years, the Government began acknowledging the Maoists as a serious problem only five years ago when Prime Minister Manmohan Singh described them as the biggest security threat to the country. Despite that, then home minister Shivraj Patil dithered on taking on the rebels, calling them "misguided children" of the country. Chidambaram formulated a proper response, which he says is careful, controlled and calibrated. But even though there is a policy in place, there are gaps and problems in implementation. The home minister

is careful not to comment on the states but the fact is that many are not on the same page as the Centre.

According to sources, the MHA is not happy with the way Bihar, Jharkhand and West Bengal have been tackling the issue. All have been believed to be playing footsie with the rebels. Jharkhand Chief Minister Shibu Soren had his private treaty with Maoists, releasing two dozen of them to secure the release of a kidnapped block development officer. In West Bengal, the UPA's own ally Mamata Banerjee was hobnobbing with them, hoping to get their support in her bid to occupy Writer's Building next year. Bihar too is lagging behind in the war. The state has failed to establish a police training institute when the existing training institute went to Jharkhand nearly 10 years ago. And despite the Centre releasing funds for police modernisation, most of the forces remain ill-equipped and untrained. The latest attack on Silda camp of the East Frontier Police exposed that the personnel were not following Standard Operating Procedures. Chidambaram is firm that all this must change. If he has his way, the Maoists may not get too many more chances. ■

MORE PEOPLE HAVE BEEN KILLED IN NAXAL VIOLENCE THAN IN KASHMIR AND NORTH-EAST MILITANCY PUT TOGETHER.
